NINE

15 January 1995

The reception we, the new cadets, received at the Air Force Academy (AFA) in Dundigal was a very cold one, far from anything I had imagined. There were no welcome signs, no cheers, nothing at all. There was only the customary silence of a disciplined life, akin to any other cantonment. The academy—located twenty-five kilometres from the twin cities of Hyderabad and Secunderabad—had been established in 1971 to train to the flying, technical and ground-duty branches, as well as officers of the army and navy. Every year, two batches of pilots graduate from the academy to proceed for further training in the fighter, transport and helicopter wings at other training establishments. When I entered the academy with my luggage, I found myself staring at the numerous vintage aircraft on display at various locations inside the academy. ‘Achievement through diligence’, the academy’s motto, was inscribed in many places. I walked past all four squadrons of the academy to reach the flight cadets’ mess (FCM), wondering whether I’d spend my training time in the Aquino, Brar, Chitnis or Katre squadrons. When I stood in front of the FCM, which stood calmly in the middle of seven thousand acres of the academy, I couldn’t help but imagine how many cadets would have started their journey right from where I was standing. We were all dressed in civvies and stood in small